FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET-UG, was designed to create a uniform standard for medical admissions across India. Instead, it has exposed the dangers of centralising a system without building adequately strong safeguards to protect its credibility. The national exam, conducted on May 3, was cancelled after allegations of a widespread question paper leak were confirmed by investigations. What was meant to create fairness and uniformity has only created a uniform mess across India. The resulting trauma is shared by 2.28 million students who appeared across 5,400-plus centres, in 565 cities. Four of them took their lives. Not surprising in times when many young Indians believe their life depends on securing one of the 129,805 seats on offer in India's 824 medical colleges, or the 27,695 seats in its 330 dental colleges. A re-test will be held on June 21, but the doubts will not disappear with that. The issue is no longer confined to one leaked paper. The deeper problem is that it is a recurring pattern that has become impossible to ignore. NEET's crisis seems less like one failure and more like institutional decay.

This year's leak did not begin at a printing press or exam centre, but at the very top of the paper setting chain. Soon after the exam, a handwritten "guess paper" of about 410 questions, circulating on WhatsApp and Telegram for up to a month before test day, was matched against the official booklet by a whistleblower in Sikar. It matched almost perfectly, covering about 600 of 720 marks. A review by the National Testing Agency (NTA), responsible for conducting the exam, confirmed around 120 of the "guess" questions appeared in the actual paper. The Chemistry section was identical, substantial parts of Biology were compromised. The CBI was brought in, not for the first time in the context of NEET. It hit a different trail this time, leading not to petty transporters or shadowy exam mafias, but to a small group of experts appointed by the NTA itself. They had the job of setting the papers, as well as translating them into Marathi. Their role meant that two Pune-based lecturers, for Chemistry and Biology, knew all 135 questions in their subjects. The Chemistry professor also ran paid coaching sessions at his home where he dictated the actual questions, options and answers; handwritten notes from those sessions matched the NEET paper perfectly. Later, the Physics questions were traced to another Pune-based NTA expert. At least two of these lecturers are suspected to have sold over 75 questions papers for about Rs 2.50 lakh each.

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From there, the network spread rapidly, via middlemen who recruited students willing to pay Rs 10-15 lakh for access to their "special" classes. The material radiated outward in the form of notes and PDFs, eventually reaching coaching hubs in Rajasthan and Maharashtra. The students who benefited unfairly could number in the hundreds. The NTA has put some two-dozen paper-setters and translators "on the radar", partly replacing its expert pool. NEET 2026 may yet be salvaged from this wreckage, but key gaps remain that pose troubling questions over past editions as well. Many from the tainted pool of translators have been there for six or seven years, so no one can guarantee there haven't been past breaches. In 2022, the CBI busted an impersonation racket in which "solvers" allegedly appeared for candidates. NEET 2024 was compromised in a way that did not find satisfactory closure. A cluster of 67 perfect scores and hundreds of near-perfect ones raised questions about the integrity of the evaluation system. Ultimately, the Supreme Court held that the problem was localised and refused to cancel the exam nationwide. That threshold has now been crossed.

This week, Managing Editor Kaushik Deka's cover story examines the full anatomy of the crisis and the reforms required to restore credibility. Some solutions only await implementation. A committee headed by former ISRO chief K. Radhakrishnan in 2024 had several recommendations. One major reform will arrive next year when NEET shifts to a computer-based test, to reduce vulnerabilities created by physical printing, transportation and storage. Going digital brings its own issues: uneven digital access, infrastructure constraints and possibility of cyber-attacks.

The larger problem is institutional. The NTA was created in 2017 as a central body to standardise entrance examinations. But neither its history nor the present inspires confidence right now. NTA director-general Abhishek Singh, who came in just a month before this mess erupted, calls for a "zero-trust architecture" all around. A system must be evolved where paper-setters do not know what exam they are setting questions for. Under such a system, experts would submit questions to a large, anonymised pool from which automated selection systems would generate final papers. That would reduce the possibility of insider compromise. Another layer of essential repair must target the NTA's own structure. There is a growing demand from medical bodies for its legal status to be converted: from a registered society into a statutory body subject to parliamentary oversight and independent audits. Or scrapped altogether.

Undoubtedly, the NEET crisis is not merely about leaked papers or rogue actors gaming the system. It is about an institution that was created to ensure credibility but now finds its own credibility under scrutiny. That must be corrected, and corrected quickly. Failure of such institutions demoralise the young who are striving for a better future.

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